

The Incentives for Risky Choices: Money, Fame, and Self-Damaging Acts on January 6th

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Abstract

The storming of the US Capitol on January 6, 2021, violated the norms of American political culture along multiple dimensions. These violations produced visual records that have become lasting, ubiquitous memories of the event. The violent acts without which the Capitol could not have been taken have left images of assault and conflict, particularly in the tunnel leading to the lower Capitol entrance. These images and many others come from a mix of official surveillance cameras and the social media streams and posts of the participants. Understanding the motives for violent acts and for the seemingly self-destructive practice of documenting individual and mass violations of laws and norms on social media is a puzzle that seemingly defies straightforward, rational explanation. Is there something like a cost-benefit calculation that helps render these behaviors intelligible, or are they more purely expressive? This essay tests whether a search for notoriety, fame, or financial reward can help explain individuals' decisions to engage in violence or to broadcast the event on social media. Using a panel of 1,036 charged defendants and six independent measures of public and right-wing-media visibility (Google search interest, InfoWars mentions, the Congressional Record, and three right-wing news outlets), estimated via three complementary panel/synthetic-control methods, I find a robust general-public visibility effect but little or no evidence of elevated recognition within right-wing media or elite political circles. However, analysis of crowdfunding on GiveSendGo finds a real, doubly-robust financial effect of violent participation (and, more weakly, of social media broadcasting) that shows no evidence of mediation by the general-public visibility increase. Together, these results suggest that selective financial incentives may help explain risky participation in January 6th.

1 Introduction

Academic and popular accounts of the attack on the U.S. Capitol on January 6th, 2021, have heavily questioned the motives and decision-making behind the violence and spectacle of the

event (Kaplan and Sapien, 2021; Grant, 2022; van Prooijen, 2024). A substantial share of this work looks to social media specifically as a proximate cause or explanatory lens, including analyses of Trump’s own tweets and their role in mobilizing the crowd (Hoffman et al., 2025; Dausch, 2024). Virtually anyone committing violence in such a highly surveilled location was likely to face serious consequences. In fact, these turned out to include death for one participant (Mandziuk, 2022; Murphy, 2026) and significant legal jeopardy for many others (Merchant, 2024). The decision to publicly document oneself while committing federal crimes on January 6th seems a similarly risky behavior, and one likely to produce some of the same negative consequences. Indeed, criminal defense practice treats self-incriminating social media activity as a hazard general enough to warrant standing advice independent of any particular case (“you must keep a very low profile speaking ONLY to your criminal defense lawyer and to NO ONE ELSE” (Steinberg, n.d.)). One must weigh these obvious risks against a vanishingly small probability that any individual participant’s actions materially changed the outcome of the event or the presidential transition (although collectively, the participants may well have had significant effects on American democracy (Castañeda and Jenks, 2023)). The expected-value calculation facing an individual January 6th participant, in other words, looks considerably worse than that facing a participant in most social-movement activity, where personal risk is often much lower even though individual contributions to the desired end may be similarly obscure.

This discussion draws on classic collective-action insights. Participation in any large-scale collective effort is individually costly while contributing only a vanishingly small marginal probability of affecting the outcome, a tension classically resolved by Olson (1965)’s argument that rational participation requires selective incentives, i.e., rewards available only to participants themselves, rather than reliance on the collective good alone. Empirical work on especially high-risk activism shows this individual-level calculus doing real work in practice. For example, McAdam (1986) finds that a substantial share of applicants accepted into Mississippi Freedom Summer, a campaign considerably less physically dangerous than January

6th, ultimately withdrew once the concrete risks of participation became salient, with eventual participation predicted less by ideological commitment than by biographical availability and preexisting organizational ties. This essay’s focus on material and reputational selective incentives specifically serves as a deliberate theoretical and empirical spotlighting of one potential dynamic that can help account for the variation in risky behavior, and should not be taken as a claim that selective incentives are the only forces at work. Indeed, a substantial literature treats moral outrage, solidarity, and the intrinsic, expressive pleasure of transgressive collective action as independently sufficient motives for high-risk participation, without any external reward at all (Jasper, 1998; Wood, 2003). The two accounts are not mutually exclusive, and there is no research design in this analysis that measures, or specifically rules out expressive and emotional motives. At the same time, these explanatory factors are likely either broadly shared among January 6th participants or, for some hypotheses, inherently collective. As such, they are not promising as an explanation of varying behaviors within the group.

This essay asks whether a search for fame, career advancement or financial reward within right-wing political and media spaces has the right incentive structure to account for participants’ varying decisions to engage in violence or to broadcast one’s participation on social media, above and beyond whatever role group membership and prior ideological commitment already play.

2 Existing Explanations and Their Limits

Existing explanations for participation in January 6th cluster into a few broad groups, each valuable for forming an in-depth understanding of the event but also leaving largely open the question of understanding why some participants, but not others, engaged in unusually risky behaviors at the Capitol.

First, there is an invaluable collection of research accounting for *who* chose to participate

in the January 6th rally and subsequent events, using structural and attitudinal predictors measured well before the event itself. Denbeaux and Crawley (2023) provide the broadest empirical baseline for this tradition, coding age, race, gender, education, employment, criminal history, financial hardship, whether a defendant acted alone or with others, and military or law enforcement background for 716 defendants directly from Department of Justice charging documents. Their central finding is that this population mirrors the broader U.S. population on most demographic dimensions, with race and gender the striking exceptions. Both the affirmative findings about race and gender, as well as the general finding that most variables do not distinguish between participants and non-participants, are important insights into the event. But both describe who showed up, not what they did once there — demographic and background similarity to the general population says nothing about why some attendees escalated to violence or public self-documentation and others did not.

The broadest and most productive research program within this approach to understanding January 6th comes from the University of Chicago’s Chicago Project on Security and Threats (CPOST). Its earliest findings, released within weeks of the event (Pape and Ruby, 2021b,a; Pape, 2021), already identified the pattern that would structure the program’s later peer-reviewed work: those arrested were disproportionately older, professional, and without ties to existing right-wing organizations, and disproportionately drawn from specific kinds of counties, including many that voted for Biden, experiencing the fastest recent declines in non-Hispanic white population share. Pape et al. (2024) formalize and extend this finding: local white population decline, more than manufacturing decline, predicts a home county’s production of insurrectionists, with the effect strengthening in districts whose representatives rejected certification. This research program’s most recent work, Pape et al. (2025), adds military veteran status as a predictor in its own right: using a nationally representative, demographically matched survey, they find veterans nearly twice as likely as non-veterans to hold high insurrectionist sentiments, and estimate that military service raises support for restoring Trump to power by force by 15 percentage points, an effect that survives adjust-

ment for prior pro-Trump or conspiratorial beliefs and for negative military and post-service experiences. These are still predictors of attendance and general insurrectionist sentiment, though, measured at the level of counties or broad demographic categories; they are silent on why one veteran from a demographically similar county assaulted an officer while another simply walked through the building and left.

Davis and Wilson (2023) and Rush et al. (2025) each connect racial attitudes directly to the event: white racial resentment and antipathy toward racial out-groups predict election-fraud belief and sympathy for the insurrection independent of partisanship and Trump favorability. Hall (2023) situates the day within a longer-run account of antidemocratic politics, arguing that a durable 25–30% segment of the American public has, across decades of survey data, combined support for social hierarchy, conspiratorial thinking, and distrust of democratic institutions. In this view, such antidemocratic attitudes provide the raw mobilizational material for a movement like this. But to the extent these attitudes are widely shared among January 6th participants themselves, they cannot also be what explains the divergent behavior within that group.

Second, a group of researchers, concentrated in a 2022 special issue of *Group Dynamics: Theory, Research, and Practice*, explain behavior at the level of the crowd itself, once assembled. Paulus and Kenworthy (2022) draw on Le Bon-style crowd psychology alongside ideas related to social identity/self-categorization to explain deindividuation and collective escalation at the Capitol. Harton et al. (2022) use dynamic social impact theory as a lens for considering how clustering and consolidation of belief among physically and socially proximate followers produced the conditions for coordinated action. Van Swol et al. (2022) look closely at the role of social media in building homogeneous, norm-reinforcing networks well before January 6th arrived, arguing that most participants were not preexisting extremists so much as people whose local information environment had normalized extreme action. Samuelson (2022) focuses on violence directed at police, using emergent norm theory and the focus theory of normative conduct to explain why the group of January 6th partici-

pants collectively abandoned the social norm against attacking law enforcement. Smith and Tindale (2022) apply a social-sharedness framework to the same events, and Rothbart and Stebbins (2023) give a group-specific account of the Proud Boys' violence as an expression of "righteous rage" central to the group's identity as self-styled defenders of the nation. It is reasonable to believe that a similar righteous rage may have been widely shared among the overall body of participants who sought to, in their worldview, "stop the steal" of a presidential election and preserve their vision of democracy and the good society. Hoerst and Drury (2023) apply this same crowd-psychology tradition directly to participant testimony, examining collective grievances alongside collective psychological empowerment, conceptualized as a sense of the ingroup's growing strength, drawn either from the event itself or, distally, from Trump's 2016 electoral victory, as potential motives. Comparing the Capitol to the 2017 Charlottesville "Unite the Right" rally, they find that collective grievance narratives, not empowerment, predominated in accounts of the Capitol event specifically. While this finding closely reads the evidence of the event, it is again pitched at the level of the crowd as a whole. That is to say, it helps explain why all of the participants mobilized into participation in the rally and insurrection, but as a broadly shared trait seems less helpful in analyzing the subgroup who escalated to violence or open self-incrimination from everyone else who attended.

Third, some scholars treat January 6th as the product of social-movement framing and identity threat rather than crowd psychology. Crothers and Burgener (2021) argue for interpreting the event as "insurrectionary populism," a social movement mobilized on behalf of what participants experience as a besieged in-group. Grant (2022) comes closest to engaging with the puzzle motivating this essay: how can we understand differences among participants? Grant argues that many January 6th participants did not look like extremists beforehand, and instead varied in meaningful ways. However, distinctions dissolve once the day arrives because the collective action was framed as a shared defense of "real Americans," an idea that predated Trump's mobilizing rhetoric that day. In a somewhat different applica-

tion of framing, Zulli et al. (2023) show how news outlets’ definitional and labeling choices in the aftermath (calling the day a riot, an insurrection, or a protest) shaped how the event was understood. This draws attention to the importance of subsequent media attention, a factor the present analysis will treat as a potential motive for decision-making on the day. While social-movement arguments have real value, they posit shared traits (of self-understanding, of existing frames, of media presentation) that would become background constants in an analysis of varied behaviors among January 6th activists.

Fourth, work drawing on criminology supplies theoretical grounding for treating far-right organizational membership as a meaningful predictor, even if we accept the Chicago group’s finding that membership was less common than expected and therefore may be limited as an explanation for participation. Valasik and Reid (2023) argue that groups like the Proud Boys are best understood using the conventional street-gang literature rather than through a domestic-terrorism lens, with the implication that these groups are durable, public oriented, rely on group symbols, and see criminal involvement as part of group identity. Their analysis of the network among the 82 Proud Boys members arrested for January 6th participation offers a concrete illustration of exactly the gap this essay is aimed at: the network is strikingly sparse, with a mean degree of only 2.25 and roughly half of those arrested having no prior relationship with one another before that day. Shared gang membership, in other words, did not imply a shared social network, let alone tightly coordinated individual behavior on January 6th itself.

Each of these traditions is informative, and control variables drawn from these literatures, including background traits, local context, and group-level psychological processes, are incorporated here where the data allow. But each explains the phenomenon at the level of the population, the crowd, or the movement, not at the level of the individual risky decision among participants on the day. This echoes the gap that motivated the broader shift in social-movements scholarship toward mechanism- and episode-level analysis of contentious action, rather than treating movements and the crowds that compose them as internally

undifferentiated actors (McAdam et al., 2001). None of these projects focuses on explaining the enormous variation in behavior *among* people who share the same structural predictors, the same crowd, and the same group affiliation. Members of the same organizations, from similar places, with similar attitudes, made starkly different choices on the day itself: some entered the Capitol and left peacefully, some assaulted police officers and others, some narrated their own felonies in real time on social media, and many did none of the above. A complete account needs some explanation for behavioral variation within, not just across, these groups.

3 A Rational-Expectations Test for the Fame Motive

One family of potential explanations, raised in both popular and scholarly commentary, points to the potential for celebrity, career advancement, and/or money within the right wing as a motive for the riskiest decisions made that day. On the celebrity side, a growing literature examines how digital and social media specifically reward this kind of self-presentation (Beck, 2026; Klein, 2025; Kovacs et al., 2022). On the money side, separate work documents that far-right figures and organizations have real, demonstrated channels for converting attention into revenue, beyond the day of January 6th (Squire, 2021; Imperati et al., 2025). It seems worthwhile to explore whether parallel dynamics happened for January 6th participants. Individual payoffs related to right-wing celebrity or crowd funding would provide the selective incentives that Olson (1965) highlights as a powerful explanation for risky or otherwise costly collective behavior. We can also draw insight from Klandermans (1984)’s formalized social-movement participation analysis: prospective participants weigh the subjective probability and magnitude of participation-specific rewards against the costs of acting, rather than weighing the collective outcome alone.

For selective incentives to be a plausible motive among a population of activists who mostly have a meaningful history with one form or another of the right wing as reflected

in their mobilization to the January 6th rally, we can expect them to be unusually well informed about the dynamics of the cultural and political space. Hence, it is useful to invoke a kind of informal rational-expectations argument: if participants who engaged in violence or broadcast their participation are *no more visible* within right-wing media or elite political circles after January 6th than participants who did neither, then a fame-seeking account of their decisions is difficult to sustain. Likewise, if people who choose risky actions receive no more crowdfunding attention than those who behave more quietly, we should conclude that financial incentives are not a plausible explanation.

4 Evaluative Asymmetry between the General Public and the Far Right

Attention from the general public, as distinct from attention within right-wing spaces, was disproportionately a negative outcome for January 6th participants. Jacobson (2024)’s review of hundreds of surveys fielded from the days after the attack through late 2023 finds that disapproval of participants was both immediate and durable: in the first national poll taken (ABC News/*Washington Post*, January 10–13, 2021), 80% of respondents strongly opposed the participants’ actions, including 60% of Trump voters who themselves denied Biden’s legitimate victory. Favorable opinions of January 6th participants started at only 9% overall in the two months after the attack and, across averaged polling through mid-2022, rose only to about 18%. Thus, January 6th supporters were a persistently small minority even as partisan characterization of the rioters (criminals, domestic terrorists, patriots, or secret leftist infiltrators) began to diverge along party lines.

Frye (2024)’s natural experiment, involving surveys with respondents both just before and in the immediate hours after the attack, adds a causal-inferential layer to this descriptive pattern. Those interviewed after the Capitol was breached were roughly ten percentage points less likely to identify as Republican and reported less favorable views of Trump than

otherwise-similar respondents surveyed only days earlier, even among self-reported Trump voters. There is some evidence of heterogeneous patterns, however: Sanchez et al. (2025), using the 2020 Collaborative Multiracial Post-Election Survey, find a curvilinear relationship between a respondent’s home-county demographic change and whether they label the day a “protest” or an “insurrection.” Specifically, moderate increases in non-white population share predict the harsher insurrection framing, while both larger and smaller demographic shifts predict the softer protest framing, a pattern that holds regardless of the respondent’s own race and is concentrated among those who did not vote for Trump. The general-public reception this section treats as a cost, in other words, was itself shaped by local context. However, the findings by Jacobson and Frye suggest that, even in the best contexts, general public reactions to participation in January 6th were at least somewhat negative in the short and medium term. If general-public notoriety functions as a disincentive rather than a reward, then a fame-seeking account of the decision to engage in violence or broadcast one’s participation needs a positive right-wing visibility effect large enough, to offset the reputational cost imposed by the general public.

To provide a different form of evidence regarding the negative tenor of public visibility for January 6th participants, as well as to offer empirical support for the idea that far-right visibility may be different, the remainder of this section offers a descriptive comparison of by a small hand-coded sample of participant coverage in the mainstream press versus right-wing venues.

4.1 Valence of coverage

Collecting and analyzing the positive or negative valence of coverage of January 6th participants poses a set of challenges. First, most general-public headlines returned by a name-plus-topic search are not specifically about the named defendant, and instead involve namesake collisions with unrelated people, or generic January 6th news that happened to satisfy the query without being coverage of that specific person. Second, and more fundamentally,

lexicon-based sentiment analysis cannot distinguish a speaker’s actual attitude from the vocabulary a topic requires: a right-wing transcript excerpt defending a defendant by minimizing her conduct (“she attended what initially began as a rally”) is likely to score as expressing a highly negative sentiment because it also engaged with terminology from the participant’s charging documents (“federally charged with a riot,” “guilty,” “insurrection”). What is needed is an approach that can discern intent, rather than word counts.

In place of a sentiment analysis, a small hand-coded sample was built and coded by four independent coders (the author and three research assistants), each blind to whether a particular text came from a right-wing or mainstream source. Fifty right-wing texts were drawn at random from the full pool of InfoWars, Drudge, Breitbart, and Newsmax items collected for this study (see further discussion below). For the mainstream, fifty headlines were drawn from a name-verified subset of Google News search results connected with specific January 6th participants (name verification is needed as an unfiltered draw of headlines would mostly be name collisions or coverage of the event as a whole, as discussed above), checked individually against the specific facts of each case. All hundred items were shuffled together, stripped of source and audience information, and coded by four independent coders using a Likert scale that ranges from “very negative” to “very positive” valence. Centering “neutral” as zero produces a scale with a range from -3 to 3 . Agreement among the four coders was tentative to acceptable by conventional standards (Krippendorff’s $\alpha = 0.782$; pairwise quadratic-weighted κ ranging from 0.646 to 0.935 across the six coder pairs). Each item’s reported score is the average of the four coders’ ratings. Mainstream media items average -0.39 on this scale, while right-wing items average $+0.97$. The difference, -1.36 , is large and statistically significant (Wilcoxon rank-sum $p < 0.001$, t -test $p < 0.001$; Figure 1), in the expected direction: mainstream media coverage leans mildly negative, right-wing coverage leans clearly sympathetic.

These results echo and extend the survey picture discussed above. We have plausible initial reason to believe that mainstream attention to January 6th participants was negative,

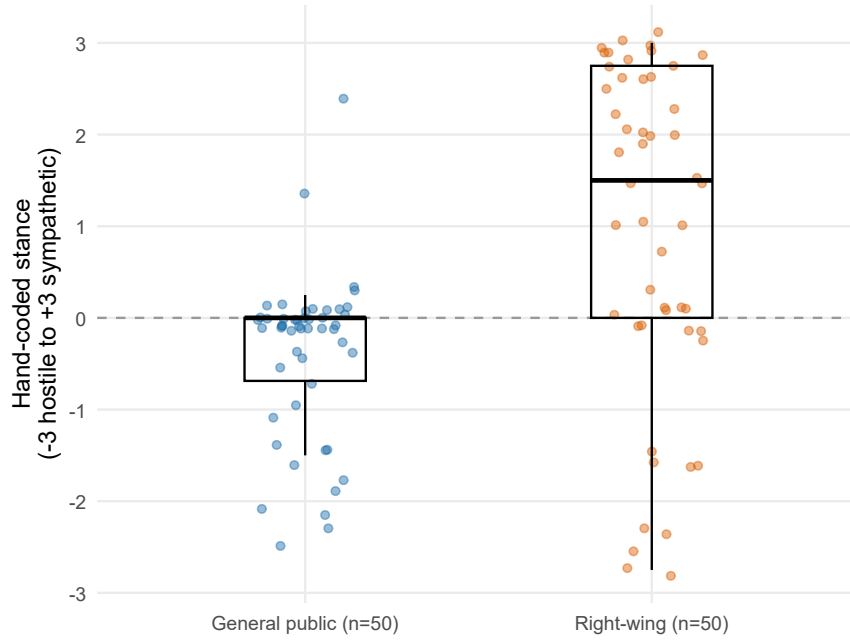


Figure 1: Distribution of hand-coded stance toward the named defendant (-3 = clearly hostile, $+3$ = clearly sympathetic), by audience, for the 50-item random right-wing sample and the 50-item name-verified general-public sample described in the text. Boxplots show the median and interquartile range; each point is one item’s score, averaged across four independent coders all blind to audience (jittered horizontally).

in media coverage and public attitude, while right-wing attention shows a distinctly more positive set of attitudes.

5 Data and Methods

The analysis draws on a sample of 1,036 defendants charged in connection with the events of January 6, 2021, coded from DOJ charging documents and related public records, restricted, as discussed immediately below, to defendants coded as having physically entered the Capitol building. Two treatments are defined from consolidated multi-coder judgments (a single “yes” from any coder overrules any number of “no” codings, given the asymmetric cost of a false negative on these variables): **T1**, whether the defendant was charged with a violence-related offense, and **T2**, whether the defendant broadcast their own participation on social media. T1 and T2 are treated throughout as answering related but distinct questions: whether violence pays off in visibility, and whether social media broadcasting leads to visibility in legacy and gatekept forms of mainstream and far-right media.

5.1 Identification: restricting to Capitol entrants

Analyzing the full population of people arrested in connection with January 6th would create a serious identification problem. Inclusion in any dataset consisting of people charged by the state is not exogenous: police and prosecutors exercise substantial discretion over whom to charge, and the factors behind that discretion are, very often, correlated with factors of interest such as, in the case of this essay, violence and social media activity. It is reasonable to imagine that the incompletely observed causes behind law enforcement choices would also influence the post-treatment visibility of the people arrested, thereby contaminating the relationship between our treatments and outcomes. This is an instance of collider bias from selecting a sample on a variable that is a common effect of the treatment and of other causes of the outcome (Knox and Mummolo, 2020). As with collider bias in general, conditioning

on inclusion in a charged-defendant dataset can induce a spurious statistical association between violence or broadcasting and later visibility, or obscure a real one, even absent any causal effect of either exposure on visibility.

In the data for this project, there is clear reason to believe that law enforcement choices shape the collection of available evidence, especially among January 6th participants who did not enter the Capitol building. Among the 1,363 charged individuals in this project’s underlying coding of DOJ charging documents for whom court records were sufficient to determine whether they entered the building and whether they were charged with violence, 68.9% of those who never entered the building (184 of 267) were charged with a violence-related offense, compared to only 22.0% of those who did enter (241 of 1,096), for an odds ratio of 0.13 (Fisher’s exact test, 95% CI [0.09, 0.17], $p < 0.001$). Charging was, in other words, considerably more discretionary, and more closely targeted on violent or otherwise aggravated conduct specifically, for participants who remained outside the Capitol building than for those who entered it. Figure 2 represents the hypothesized explanatory structure here as two simple directed acyclic graphs. Outside the building, where the population of participants was large and diffuse, charging resources appear to have been concentrated on cases involving violence, theft, or other conduct that drew specific attention, leaving many nonviolent bystanders uncharged, unidentified, and therefore absent from the data. Under this kind of severity-targeted discretion, the treatment T has a direct causal effect on whether someone is charged C at all; if unobserved notability U (e.g., a distinctive appearance on camera, an existing public profile) independently affects both charging and later visibility Y , then conditioning on inclusion in the dataset (which analysis of charged defendants must implicitly do) opens a spurious statistical path between T and Y even absent a direct causal effect.

Inside the building, by contrast, extensive surveillance camera coverage combined with defendants’ own social media documentation appears to have produced a very high rate of charging of identifiable individuals, largely independent of whether their conduct involved

violence. Given the political salience of the event, police and prosecutors may have acted as if they had no discretion with respect to people who were documented inside the building, and the elevated availability of surveillance and social-media footage in the Capitol that day also seems to have reduced any selection problem related to the identification of specific individuals. If this interpretation is correct, then defining the population to consist of people who entered the Capitol severs the $T \rightarrow C$ edge and closes the spurious path.

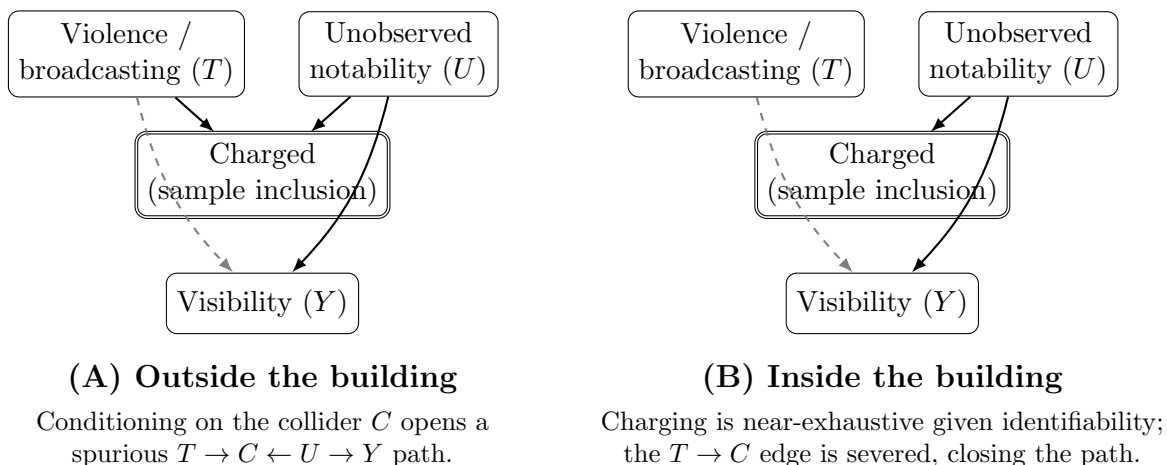


Figure 2: Stylized causal diagrams for the collider-bias concern motivating this essay’s restriction to Capitol entrants (cf. Knox and Mummolo, 2020). Both panels condition on inclusion in a charged-defendant dataset (double-bordered node), which is required simply for a defendant to be observed at all. Outside the building (panel A), charging was targeted and discretionary, concentrated on violent or otherwise aggravated conduct, so the treatment T has a real causal effect on being charged C ; because unobserved notability U plausibly affects both charging (e.g., through distinctive identifiability) and later visibility Y , conditioning on C opens a spurious statistical path between T and Y (solid black arrows) even absent the direct causal effect of interest (dashed grey arrow). Inside the building (panel B), extensive video and social media evidence made charging close to exhaustive for identifiable individuals regardless of T : there is no edge from T to C , closing the spurious path.

The sample used throughout this essay is accordingly restricted to defendants coded as having physically entered the Capitol building. Entry status was determined using the same consolidated multi-coder procedure used for T1 and T2 above (any coder’s “yes” overrules any number of “no” codings), applied to the 1,363 charged individuals described above; 1,096 were coded as having entered the building, and the 1,036 with usable outcome data across the study’s other inclusion criteria make up the final analytic sample. This restriction does

not eliminate every source of selection into the dataset, as prosecutorial discretion inevitably still operates to some extent, even among identified building entrants, but it removes the specific, well-documented, and severity-correlated form of discretion that would otherwise pose the most direct threat to this essay’s causal claims.

5.2 Visibility outcomes

Six independent sources measure visibility, spanning general-public attention, sympathetic right-wing media, and elite/legislative recognition. **Google Trends** scores for each participant’s name serve as a measure of general-public interest in each person over time by capturing the prevalence of web searches for each person. These scores were normalized by including one constant name (Owen Shroyer) in every search and always dividing all scores by Shroyer’s highest value. Counts of mentions of each January 6th participant on broadcasts published by Alex Jones’s **InfoWars** network (based on searching within the helpful corpus of episode transcripts collected at fight.fudgie.org) provide insight into visibility within one of the most prominent far-right media domains. These are supplemented with counts of mentions of each participant within the collection of archived published material searchable on the website of **The Drudge Report**, **Breitbart**, and **Newsmax**; while these publish at a lower volume than InfoWars, including all of these as alternative versions of far-right visibility provides a safety net in the face of idiosyncratic coverage by any one source. To guard for the possibility of differences between audio-video discourse (InfoWars) and the remaining far-right sources, as well as the possibility of ideological or personal heterogeneity across the editorial teams, each of these far-right visibility outcomes is analyzed as a separate dependent variable. Finally, mentions of each participant within the **Congressional Record** (searched via the GovInfo API) offers insight into the visibility of each January 6th participant among political elites (primarily Republicans).

Each source is constructed as a weekly panel per defendant, zero-inclusive (no mention in a given week is a real value, not a missing observation), with two outcome versions:

an inverse-hyperbolic-sine (IHS) transform of the raw count (primary) and a binary any-mention indicator (companion). Name-matching for every source draws on each defendant’s legal name plus verified real aliases, with a documented, source-specific blocklist of confirmed name collisions (e.g., roster aliases that collide with public figures who had a Wikipedia page established before 2016) excluded from search.

5.3 Panel estimation

Treatment effects on each visibility outcome are estimated with three complementary methods: generalized synthetic control (`gsynth`, Xu, 2017), synthetic difference-in-differences (`synthdid`, Arkhangelsky et al., 2021), and matrix completion (`MCPanel`, Athey et al., 2021). Each of these is designed for creating average treatment effects from synthetic control-type structures including several treatment cases. For these estimators, no covariates are included (as time-invariant covariates are absorbed by unit fixed effects) and inference is conducted via unit permutation (Pesarin and Salmaso, 2010). Agreement across all three estimators is treated as a meaningfully stronger signal than any single estimator’s result. For each estimator, treatment is analyzed as happening on January 6, 2021, rather than on the day charges are published or a social-media post gains mass attention. This avoids complications where the outcome (visibility) could co-determine the timing of the treatment.

`gsynth` and `synthdid` each supply a native variance estimator (a parametric bootstrap and a jackknife, respectively), both confirmed stable across all 24 outcome-by-treatment panels by direct testing, and Figures 3 and 4 report the resulting 95% confidence intervals alongside the permutation-test significance markers. `MCPanel` has no native variance estimator, so a resampling procedure was used instead, following the suggestion in Athey et al. (2021, Sec. 4.4): for each of 12 replicates, a random subset of the observed (untreated) cells is held out, the regularization parameter is re-selected by cross-validation on that specific replicate, and the model is refit; the spread of the resulting ATT estimates across replicates provides a normal-approximation confidence interval. This procedure was validated by

checking it against the permutation test before trusting it: on the four Trends panels, the two agree cleanly (both flag the effect as significant). On all 20 remaining (far-right/elite) panels, however, the resampling interval excludes zero even where the permutation test finds nothing (typically p between 0.25 and 0.7) — a systematic disagreement, not scattered noise, that tracks exactly the panels where the underlying outcome is sparse and zero-inflated enough that `MCPanel`’s regularization parameter sits at or near a degenerate floor value. The most plausible interpretation is that for these outcomes, `mcnnm.fit`’s fitted counterfactual is nearly deterministic regardless of which control cells are held out, so the resampling interval reflects the stability of the fitting procedure rather than genuine precision about the treatment effect. Given this, `MCPanel`’s resampling interval is reported only for the four Trends panels (Figure 3); for the far-right/elite panels (Figure 4), `MCPanel` is shown as a point estimate only, as in the original design, rather than plotting an interval that would visually overstate the evidence for an effect the other two estimators and the permutation test do not find.

5.4 GiveSendGo funding analysis

GiveSendGo crowdfunding cannot be fit into this synthetic-control panel framework. After all, there were no January 6th fundraisers for anyone before the event took place. Therefore, every unit has constant values of zero during the pre-treatment period. Furthermore, available records make it difficult to systematically record fund-raising progress over time.

Hence, the funding outcome is instead a cross-sectional analysis. Data collection here faced meaningful challenges. Most January 6th crowdfunding campaigns are now private or deleted, such that searching GiveSendGo yields minimal results. Instead, the final design records campaigns that were publicized at some point between 2021 and the end of 2024 on one of three third-party directories of January 6th defendants (the Patriot Freedom Project (<https://patriotfreedomproject.com/>), the Patriot Mail Project (<https://patriotmailproject.com/>), and American Gulag (<https://americangulag.org/>)). Two of these directories (Patriot Freedom Project and Patriot Mail Project) are no longer available on the relevant website, and

indeed the Patriot Mail Project website has been entirely shut down. Additionally, there is no guarantee that crowdfunding listings on American Gulag are complete relative to the period of active prosecution and incarceration of January 6th participants prior to Donald Trump’s pardon. Hence, these directories were recovered from historical Internet Archive snapshots. Then, each listed GiveSendGo campaign was also searched in the Internet Archive, with data collected from the latest archival snapshot that contained information.

Campaigns were matched to the study roster by fuzzy name matching and, where possible, directly verified against the substantive content of the GiveSendGo campaign. This process uncovered confirmed crowdfunding campaigns connected to 130 January 6th participants. Where a campaign was confirmed to exist but its dollar total could not be recovered from any available historical snapshot, the participant is coded as having a campaign with the dollar amount left missing. A small number of campaigns involved pooled, multi-defendant funds rather than an individual’s own fundraiser (e.g., an attorney-managed legal defense trust serving 30 named clients), and the resulting dollar amounts are split evenly across their documented recipients rather than credited in full to each.

The outcome is estimated two ways: a doubly-robust average treatment effect on the treated (ATT), via `DoubleML`’s (Bach et al., 2024) interactive regression model (ATTE score, cross-fitted LASSO-penalized nuisance functions, 5-fold/10-repetition cross-fitting), for both a binary (*has_campaign*) and a continuous (IHS-transformed total raised, restricted to defendants with a fully known amount) outcome version; and, as a simpler cross-check, a 2×2 contingency table with Fisher’s exact test. The binary version of the dependent variable tests selection into having a visible fundraising campaign, while the continuous outcome explores variation in fundraising success, conditional on having an observable campaign.

5.5 Mediation check

This analysis treats crowdfunding campaigns as a separate potential incentive relative to media and general-public visibility. This separation would be called into question if it turns

out that these forms of visibility cause crowdfunding. As will be seen below, there is no need to worry about this threat vis-a-vis far-right visibility, as there is little evidence of a connection between our treatments of interest and those outcomes. To test whether any effect of violence and/or social media broadcasting on GiveSendGo funding operates through a pathway involving general-public visibility, potentially tangling these two outcomes together, a causal mediation analysis (Imai et al., 2010) decomposes each treatment’s total effect on GiveSendGo funding into an average causal mediation effect (ACME, the portion running through peak post-treatment Trends visibility during the period from January 6th through the end of the Biden administration) and an average direct effect (ADE, the remainder). This analysis rests on sequential ignorability, i.e., the assumption of no unobserved confounding between the mediator and the outcome, given treatment and covariates. This is, of course, a substantially stronger assumption than the single-treatment ignorability the rest of the design relies on, and is reported alongside a sensitivity analysis (Tingley et al., 2014) rather than as a standalone conclusion.

6 Results

6.1 General-public visibility (Google Trends)

All four underlying panels (two treatments, two outcome versions), across all three estimators, show a significant, positive, consistently signed effect (Figure 3).

Both treatments produce a real, consistently estimated increase in general-public search interest.

6.2 Right-wing and elite recognition

None of the four remaining sources shows a consistent positive effect. Congressional Record, Drudge, Breitbart, and Newsmax are null across every estimator for both treatments, with the three panel estimators agreeing closely in both sign and magnitude on nearly every panel

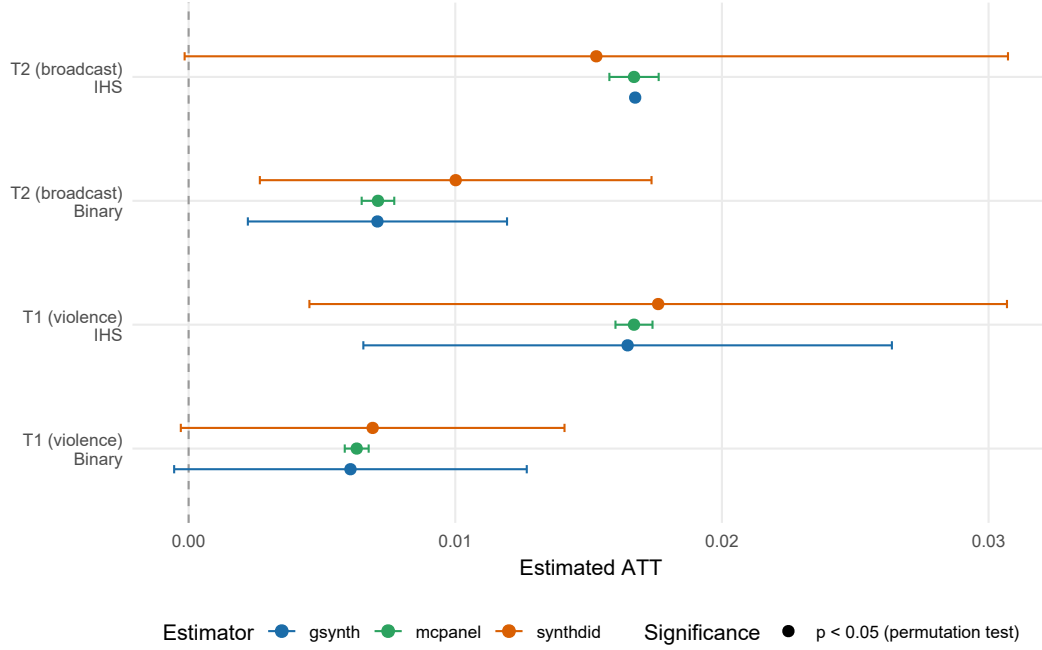


Figure 3: Google Trends ATT estimates, by treatment, outcome coding (binary vs. IHS-transformed), and estimator. For **gsynth** (parametric bootstrap, 200 replications) and **synthdid** (jackknife), error bars show a real 95% confidence interval; both were confirmed stable across every panel in this study by direct testing. **MCPANEL** has no native variance estimator, so error bars here show a resampling-based interval (Section 5.3) that was validated against the permutation test on these four panels before being trusted; that same interval is not used in Figure 4, where it does not hold up to the same check. Marker fill encodes significance from the same unit-permutation test reported throughout the paper’s text (solid = $p < 0.05$ under that test; all twelve estimates shown here are solid), kept as the significance criterion for all three estimators so it stays consistent with every other significance claim in this essay.

— a pattern consistent with a genuine null, not merely low power. InfoWars mention counts are the one exception worth flagging rather than treating as evidence either way: several panels are statistically significant, but the sign of the estimated effect flips between `gsynth` and `synthdid` on the same panel, which is itself evidence against treating the result as robust. Figure 4 shows all five sources directly, so the contrast with Figure 3’s consistently positive, well-estimated Trends effect is visible rather than only described: confidence intervals are tight and straddle zero for Congressional Record, Drudge, Breitbart, and Newsmax, while InfoWars is the one panel where estimates are both larger in magnitude and inconsistent in sign across estimators, visibly the least trustworthy result in the figure rather than a second real effect.

6.3 GiveSendGo funding

Both the simple descriptive comparison and the doubly-robust ATT estimates show a real financial effect, concentrated in T1 (Figure 5).

Violence produces both a higher probability of having any GiveSendGo campaign at all and, conditional on some campaign evidence, a higher total raised. Broadcasting shows the same directional pattern but is weaker and less consistent — not significant on whether a campaign exists at all, only (marginally) on the amount raised.

The mediation analysis finds no evidence that this financial effect runs through the general-public visibility increase in Section 6.1: the ACME is close to zero and never statistically distinguishable from zero across all four treatment-by-outcome combinations, while the ADE (the portion of the effect *not* running through Trends visibility) accounts for essentially the entire total effect in every specification. This favors an independent financial channel over a story in which crowdfunding donors are simply responding to the same general-public attention spike captured by search interest.

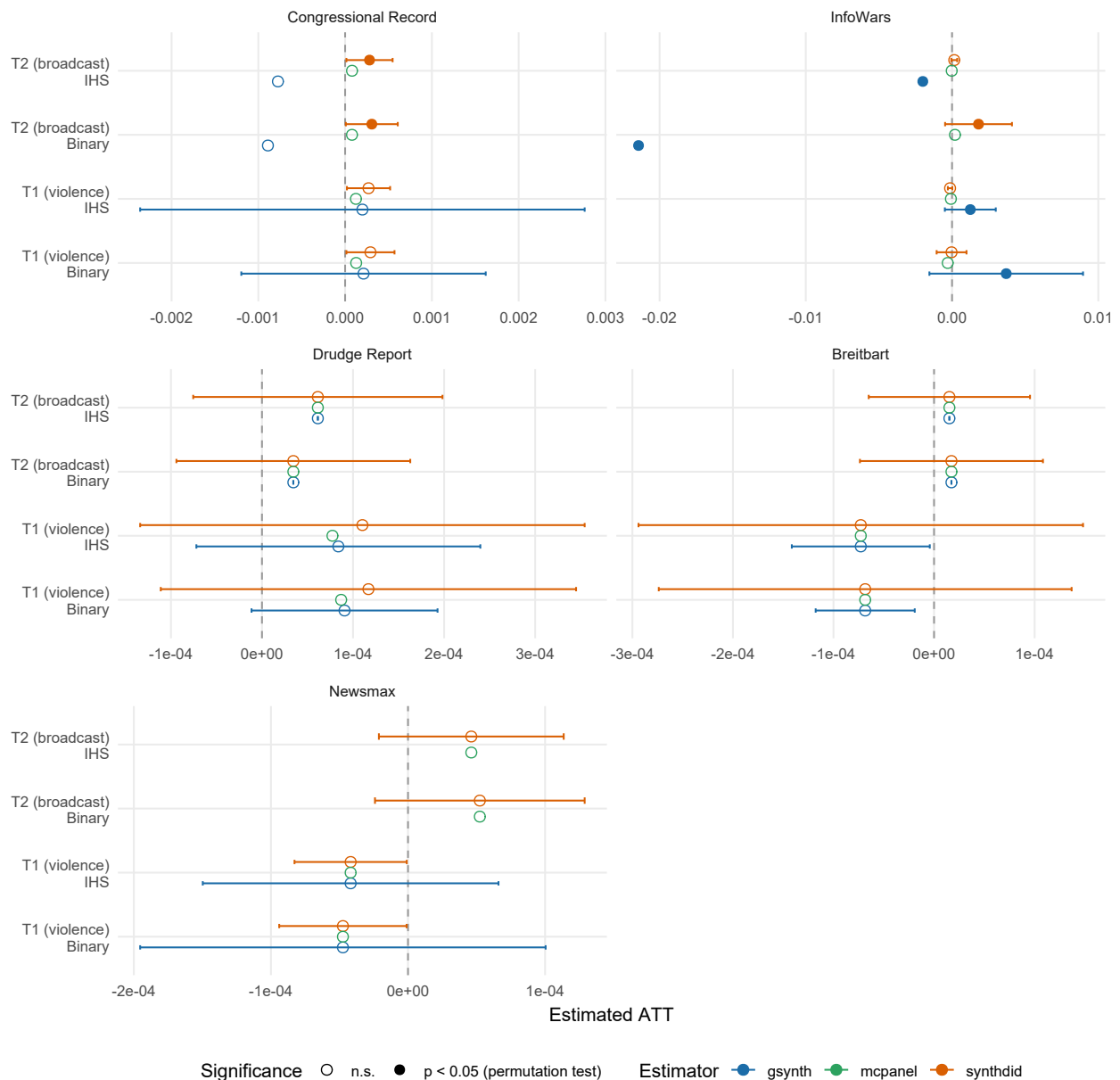


Figure 4: ATT estimates for the four right-wing/elite-media outcomes and InfoWars, by treatment, outcome coding, and estimator, faceted by source. Same conventions as Figure 3 for `gsynth` and `synthdid`. `MCPANEL` is shown as a point estimate only here, unlike in Figure 3: its resampling-based interval was checked against the permutation test for these sparser, more zero-inflated outcomes and found systematically miscalibrated (Section 5.3), so it is omitted here rather than plotted in a way that would overstate the evidence. Note the very different x -axis scale in the InfoWars panel, driven by a small number of estimates with large magnitude and inconsistent sign across estimators — the instability described in the text, not a second positive finding to set against Figure 3.

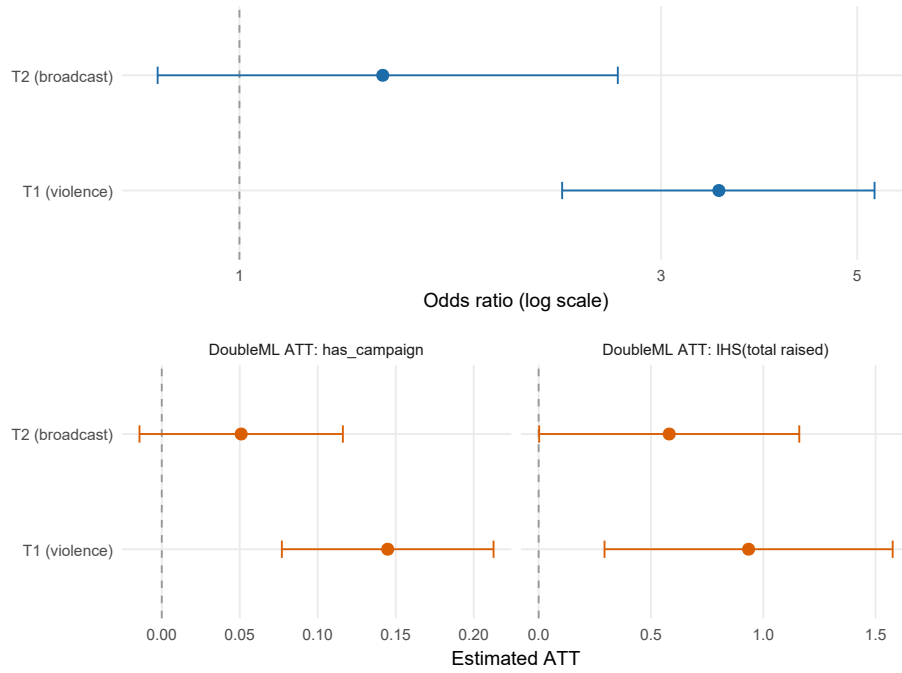


Figure 5: GiveSendGo estimates. Top: Fisher's exact odds ratio for having any campaign at all, with the exact confidence interval, by treatment. Bottom: doubly-robust (DoubleML, ATTE score) estimates of the average treatment effect on the treated, faceted by outcome, with asymptotic 95% confidence intervals from cross-fitted estimation.

7 Discussion

Taken together, the visibility results support a specific and somewhat counterintuitive conclusion. There is coherent evidence of a general-public visibility effect for both violent participation and social media broadcasting — but little or no evidence of a corresponding effect within right-wing media or elite political circles. Given that general-public attention functioned, if anything, as a documented reputational cost for January 6th participants (Section 4), this pattern is difficult to square with a pure fame-seeking account of the decision to engage in violence or broadcast one’s participation: participants who took on this cost do not appear to have received an offsetting reputational benefit within the audience whose good opinion would plausibly have mattered most to them.

This null finding converges with independent evidence at a different unit of analysis. Dahlke and Pan (2024) track elite conservative activity on Twitter and Gab across the year following January 6th and find that neither bursts of defendant arrests nor bursts of media coverage about January 6th produced any detectable increase in movement activity on either platform — the online right, in aggregate, simply did not re-engage around defendant-related news events. That finding is about collective mobilization rather than any individual defendant’s own visibility, and this essay’s panels are about the latter, but the two results point the same direction: events tied to January 6th defendants, whether individual or collective, do not appear to reliably generate renewed right-wing attention.

The GiveSendGo results complicate a purely reputational story in a different direction. At least some participants — disproportionately those charged with violence, and more weakly those who broadcast their participation — received a real material reward in the form of crowdfunding support (Visser, 2024; Snyder and Wilson, 2025), and this reward does not appear to be a downstream consequence of the general-public attention spike documented above. This pushes toward an account in which selective incentives for the riskiest January 6th behaviors, to the extent they existed at all, operated through financial rather than reputational channels. This is consistent with, but distinct from, the reputational-fame

hypothesis this essay set out to test: the currency that appears to have rewarded risk-taking was not standing within the right wing as a cultural or political space, but money from a sympathetic donor base — an important distinction for how these decisions should be understood, since it points toward a more transactional and narrower incentive structure than a generalized quest for right-wing celebrity would imply.

None of this rules out that the underlying decisions were substantially expressive or emotional — made in the moment, without a clear calculation of consequences at all — rather than instrumentally rational along any axis. The absence of a reputational payoff and the presence of a partial, selective financial one are both compatible with a story in which most participants acted on sincere belief and only a minority’s behavior was meaningfully shaped by anticipated reward of either kind. The hand-coded check in Section 4.1 — a secondary measurement from a small, hundred-item sample, not a central pillar of this paper’s evidence — echoes the survey-based disapproval picture already presented earlier in this section and extends it to the right-wing side: coverage of these defendants leans mildly negative in general-public sources and clearly sympathetic in right-wing ones, the direction the payoff-asymmetry argument predicts. Given the sample’s modest size, it is best read as consistent with, rather than as independent confirmation of, the survey evidence that already carries the weight of this section’s cost-side claim.

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